Boom Blox For Wii

Steven Spielberg, along with Electronic Arts, is on the verge of releasing a puzzle game Boom Blox for kids. The game has over 300 levels, several unique game modes and 30-odd characters, which could be altered and customised with an editor.

Free Music On Mobile

Nokia has signed up a deal with Sony BMG to provide free access for a year, to artists from Sony BMG for specific phone models branded under "Comes With Music"branded cellphones by the end of the year.

Enter

TECH TALK

Zeno Colaço
Vice-President, Publisher & Developer Relations, Sony Computer Entertainment Europe

SCEE's Zeno Colaço was in Mumbai for DevStation 2008 this April—Sony's first in India

What do you expect to get out of DevStation Mumbai 08?
Firstly, we're really excited about our first technical conference for Indian game developers. We intend to give them assistance in developing games for our platforms, and reduce the barriers to their entry in the market. We're also looking to provide commercial assistance—kit loans, consultancy, and perhaps even publishing.

What's the Indian game development scene for your platform been like thus far?
We've not had games come out of India yet, but we know that the technical knowhow is here. We're funding a project based on Hanuman right now, and we're looking for more such projects—properties that will appeal to the Indian market. What we're definitely *not* doing is telling developers what to develop.

What platform are you focusing your efforts on, and why?
For DevStation 08, the main focus is the PS2—we have a huge install base in the Indian market waiting to be tapped into, with specific games developed for Indians. We also have about 120 million PS2s worldwide, so exporting these games will be a lot easier. We're not ignoring the PS3, but it will still take some time for it to grow into a larger market.

How much life do you think the PS2 has left?
In the next next 12-18 months, we should hit 50 million units in the Asia-Pacific market—a 20-25 per cent growth. The PS2 will continue to be a viable platform for the next 3-4 years at least, and key developers and publishers realise that too. It's priced right, and will coexist happily with the PS3, just like the original PlayStation did with the PS2.

MORALS BEFORE MONEY

Hope For Kids

Child porn is one of the toughest evils our society faces today. Paedophilia and other sickening crimes against sweet and joy-filled kids only depict the levels to which mankind can stoop. However strongly we may try to deny it, reality bites! Even though it's been around for long, it was the Internet which unfortunately led to it becoming a mass phenomenon. The Internet simplified distribution of media of all kinds, which was traditionally the most difficult to do. As Web sites proliferated, money flowed in and the exploitation and child abuse increased. Taking advantage of poor economic conditions, criminals have managed to lure children, many of them less than ten years of age, with some as young as two. The results are a schocking tale—disturbing pictures of them being sexually abused to a worldwide audience.

Fortunately, many organisations have now started dedicated efforts to curb the spread of child porn. A few years ago, Microsoft donated $1 million for fighting under age porn. Google, on its part has vowed to block child porn related advertisements. Recently, cell phone operators across Europe and Africa got together to found the Mobile Alliance Against Child Sexual Abuse to ban these images from cellular networks. With all the efforts commonly targetting this social evil, governments

and law enforcement agencies have started a worldwide crack down. However, as a result of the online patronage, one Website would replace another that was blocked.

After sustained efforts, there is finally some good news for organisations and activists working for the welfare of children—the number of Web sites peddling child porn has actually decreased. From a peak of 3,052 such sites in 2006, the number has fallen to 2,752 last year. All these Web sites are in English, and most of them are based in Russia and the US. According to the Internet Watch Foundation (IWF), an NGO that monitors these efforts, it is possible to put an end to this crime with more manageable number of sites and an agreement in place with hosting companies that stipulate the taking down of child porn Web sites.

If everything goes according to plan, the Net will be a lot safer for the next generation.

BIG BLUE'S TWISTER

Spinning Electrons To Store Data

Hard drives and Flash drives, two most commonly used memory devices have their own pros and cons. While hard drives are cheap, easy to fabricate and can provide terabytes of storage, they are not very reliable and also very fragile. Flash memory, on the other hand, is quite rugged, yet wear out after repeated use and are relatively expensive. Another option is combining hard drives and flash memories—a data storage medium that is cheap and easy to make and maintain with almost unlimited storage! Manufacturers have for long been researching this area. Now IBM claims to have hit the jackpot by inventing such a medium and plans to introduce it to the market after four years.

Referred to as "racetrack" by scientists, this data storage medium is based on spintronics—a physical phenomenon that uses the charge and spin properties of electrons to store data. When there is a need to read or write data, an electric charge is passed through the nano wire, causing magnetic domains to move and data to be transferred.

IBM has been working on this project using the spin properties of atoms for four years. In the latest prototypes, current pulses were used with a frequency the same as the resonant frequency of the nano wire. As a result, the current requirement has been reduced by five-folds, making this new technology more practical. The fabrication of the nanowires, as well as the ability to move the domains linearly are the main challenges.

Thousands of nanowires can be accommodated by fabrication on a silicon chip, thereby making further miniaturisation of memory a reality. Once the fabrication process is perfected, the memory chips will be virtually indestructible, consume very low power and reliably store huge amounts of data.

Security Watch

Vulnerabilities in Flash Player

The problem

Adobe recently found critical vulnerabilities in Adobe Flash Player version 9.0.115.0 and 8.0.39.0 and previous versions.

If Web sites carrying malware in an SWF file, e-mails or links leading to SWF source files are accessed, then it invites the arbitrarily malicious code to reside on the computer and run remotely.

Solution

Similar to Adobe Reader and Acrobat, vulnerabilities in Adobe products are announced with a solution by Adobe. Well, that's all secondary—what you need to do is to download and install the latest version of Adobe Flash Player from **http://lin.cr/ac.** The player must be updated to the latest version 9.0.124.0 either by fresh download or using auto-update.

With this update, the potential issues of DNS rebinding attack can be mitigated. The code parameters for the cross-domain policy will be updated from 'always' to 'sameDomain' for all SWF players from version 7 and earlier. Thus, the process of cross-domain policy files becomes stricter.

HOT **Windows 7**

Touch-based inputs, and MinWin that basically is the new kernel that uses almost negligible amounts of memory. Windows 7 will be much zippier than Vista, or so we hear... let's wait and watch

NOT **So Soon?**

"But you just made me pay for Vista?" is the standard user response to the announcement of Windos 7.

It's only fairtoo... since XP did last many years, and already many feel that Vista wasn't needed. Again, wait and watch.

LEAVE SILICON ALONE

Pushing Boundaries

Conventional silicon chips are fast approaching the boundaries imposed by physical laws, at least in terms of the number of transistors that can be squeezed in a given surface area. For quite a while now, chipmakers have been looking at alternate materials that can overcome these limitations of silicon and stay in line with the popular Moore's law without unpleasant consequences—like overheating and data corruption.

IBM and a host of partners from the semiconductor industry have recently announced the discovery of one such material. Referred to as

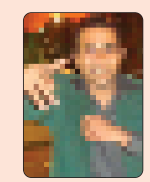
How green are your computing habits? **Opinion Poll**

A I print only what's essential
B I unplug all appliances when not in use
C I donate/recycle old computer parts
D I'm not very green, but I can improve

I work with frequently changing scripts, so if I keep taking print outs, then there would be a lot wastage. Hence, I wait for the final draft, until then I continue with my work with a pencil or pen. This way I save at least a tree or two.
Jaladhi Chhaya
Baroda

I guess by unplugging your appliances first and foremost cut downs your elecrticity bills to large extent and saves money. Also when not required, the system should be shutdown and unplugged to save them from damage.
Netra Parikh
Mumbai

Since they are becoming scarce, energy generated from renewable and non-renewable sources of energy needs to be saved. If a single man saves energy, imagine how much energy could be saved when the whole world starts acting wisely.
Ashish Tiwari
Delhi



"I choose 4. I am a designer by profession and it is very important for me to check how the final design looks like on paper. Unless some way is invented, there no way in which I see myself going 'green' "
Yashwant Miranda
Delhi.

"I choose option 2. I'm normally the one who leaves office last, ensuring that all the computers on my way out are switched off. It's just my small way of giving back to the planet."
Akhil Singh
Delhi

My choice is option 2. When you're not going to be using it for a long time, turn it off. The same can be said for peripherals, too. It all adds up. Not only will you save energy and money, you'll also protect your computer from unneces-sary wear and tear.
Jeet Patel
Pune

(You, too, can participate in this poll—at **www.thinkdigit.com**)

■ Distributed computing project for earthquake monitoring coming soon in California ■ Europe clears use of mobiles on aircrafts

■ Open standard Linux-based mobile device platform LiMO released ■ IBM launches Mashup Suite, a mashup application for businesses